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**Questions 673–738 — Difficulty: Medium**

673. Airline representative: The percentage of flight delays caused by airline error decreased significantly this year. This indicates that airlines listened to complaints about preventable errors and addressed the problems. Although delays caused by weather and other uncontrollable factors will always be part of travel, preventable delays are clearly decreasing.

Which of the following most clearly points to a logical flaw in the representative's reasoning?

A. Airlines may be motivated by financial concerns to underreport the percentage of flight delays caused by airline error.

B. The delays caused by uncontrollable factors could have led to an increase in complaints to airlines.

C. Complaints may not be the most reliable measure of how many errors occurred in a given year.

D. Delays caused by weather and other uncontrollable factors could have increased dramatically during the year under discussion.

E. Airline customers might not believe that particular delays were caused by uncontrollable factors rather than airline error.

**Argument Evaluation**

**Situation** According to an airline representative, the percentage of flight delays caused by airline error decreased significantly this year. The representative concludes that airlines have addressed preventable errors reported by travelers.

**Reasoning** *Which of the answer choices most clearly suggests a logical flaw in the reasoning of the airline representative?* Flight delays can be caused in many ways: for example, by unpredictable bad weather, mechanical or computer failures, bad management, or some combination of these. Some but not all errors of these kinds—and the flight delays they might cause—are preventable. Note that the argument is focused on *the percentage* of all flight delays that are airline-error (AE) delays. This percentage can decrease by (1) a reduction in the number of AE delays or (2) an increase in the number of non-AE delays, i.e., those delays that the airline could not have prevented. Even if a significant increase occurred in the number of AE delays, such delays could have decreased as a percentage of all flight delays if there had been a large enough increase in non-AE flight delays.

A. The hypothesis stated in this answer choice offers a slight, indirect basis for wondering whether the information on which the representative bases the reasoning is accurate. However, it provides no direct grounds for supposing that the reasoning itself is logically flawed. Even to the extent that this gives any reason to doubt the truth of the purported information, the relevance is very indirect. Even if airlines *may* have a motivation to underreport the percentage of flight delays caused by airline error, there is little reason to suppose that the representative's information may be a result of any airline's acting on such a motivation. And the representative argues on the basis of a decrease in the percentage, not on the basis of any particular percentage. If airlines systematically underreported the percentages, a decrease would still likely be significant.

B. This is only remotely relevant because the representative's quantitative comparison is about a difference in percentage of actual delays due to certain factors, not about a difference in numbers of complaints about such delays. In principle, if the total number of complaints increased and the increase was at least partially attributable to delays caused by uncontrollable factors, this information could suggest that the number of delays caused by uncontrollable factors might have increased. This, in turn, could indirectly suggest the hypothesis stated in answer choice D. But at best the relevance of answer choice B to such a hypothesis is very oblique and conjectural.

C. The issue being discussed primarily concerns flight delays. Airlines could make many kinds of errors that do not lead to flight delays and that generally do not elicit complaints from air travelers.

D. **Correct.** As explained above, if there is a large enough increase in non-AE flight delays—delays entirely due to factors outside an airline's control—then the overall number of flight delays also increases, provided the number of AE flight delays remains constant or also increases. So, even if the number of AE flight

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the number of AE flight delays remains constant or also increases. So, even if the number of AE flight delays did not decrease, the percentage of all flight delays that were AE flight delays could decrease.

E. Air travelers who experience flight delays and disbelieve the explanations given by airlines for those delays may be justified in doing so—but in many, or even most, cases also may be mistaken. We have no information as to how this would affect the number of complaints from travelers. Certainly, the general level of trust between airlines and their customers does not affect the facts regarding the rate of AE flight delays or the rate of non-AE flight delays.

**The correct answer is D.**

674. Although the school would receive financial benefits if it had soft drink vending machines in the cafeteria, we should not allow them. Allowing soft drink machines there would not be in our students' interest. If our students start drinking more soft drinks, they will be less healthy.

The argument depends on which of the following?

A. If the soft drink vending machines were placed in the cafeteria, students would consume more soft drinks as a result.

B. The amount of soft drinks that most students at the school currently drink is not detrimental to their health.

C. Students are apt to be healthier if they do not drink soft drinks at all than if they just drink small amounts occasionally.

D. Students will not simply bring soft drinks from home if the soft drink vending machines are not placed in the cafeteria.

E. The school's primary concern should be to promote good health among its students.

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** Allowing soft drink vending machines in a school cafeteria would financially benefit the school, but students who drink more soft drinks would become less healthy.

**Reasoning** *What must be true in order for the claim that students drinking more soft drinks would cause them to become less healthy to justify the conclusion that soft drink vending machines should not be allowed in the cafeteria?* The argument is that because drinking more soft drinks would be unhealthy for the students, allowing the vending machines would not be in the students' interest, so the vending machines should not be allowed. This reasoning depends on the implicit factual assumption that allowing the vending machines would result in the students drinking more soft drinks. It also depends on the implicit value judgment that receiving financial benefits should be less important to the school than preventing a situation that would make the students less healthy.

A. **Correct.** If the cafeteria vending machines would not result in students consuming more soft drinks, then allowing the machines would not harm the students' health in the way the argument assumes.

B. Even if the amount of soft drinks the students currently drink were unhealthy, enabling the students to drink more could make them even less healthy.

C. Even if drinking small amounts of soft drinks occasionally would not harm the students, vending machines in the cafeteria could lead the students to drink excessive amounts.

D. Even if students who cannot buy soft drinks in the cafeteria sometimes bring them from home instead, adding vending machines in the cafeteria could increase the students' overall soft drink consumption.

E. A concern does not have to be the primary one in order to be valid and important. It could be held that promoting students' good health should not be the schools' primary concern but should still be a more important concern than the financial benefits from the vending machines.

**The correct answer is A.**

675. Many athletes inhale pure oxygen after exercise in an attempt to increase muscular reabsorption of oxygen. Measured continuously after exercise, however, the blood lactate levels of athletes who inhale pure oxygen are practically identical, on average, to those of athletes who breathe normal air. The lower the blood lactate level is, the higher the muscular reabsorption of oxygen is.

If the statements above are all true, they most strongly support which of the following conclusions?

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If the statements above are all true, they most strongly support which of the following conclusions?

A. Athletes' muscular reabsorption of oxygen is not increased when they inhale pure oxygen instead of normal air.

B. High blood lactate levels cannot be reduced.

C. Blood lactate levels are a poor measure of oxygen reabsorption by muscles.

D. The amount of oxygen reabsorbed by an athlete's muscles always remains constant.

E. The inhaling of pure oxygen has no legitimate role in athletics.

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** Blood lactate levels after exercise are practically identical in athletes who breathe normal air and in those who inhale pure oxygen after exercise. The lower the blood lactate level, the higher the muscular reabsorption of oxygen.

**Reasoning** *What conclusion do the stated facts most strongly support?* We are told that lower blood lactate levels correspond consistently to higher muscular reabsorption of oxygen. Since athletes who breathe pure oxygen after exercise have blood lactate levels practically identical to those in athletes who breathe normal air, probably muscular reabsorption of oxygen does not differ significantly between athletes who breathe pure oxygen and those who breathe pure air.

A. **Correct.** As explained above, the stated facts suggest that muscular reabsorption of oxygen does not differ significantly between athletes who breathe pure oxygen and those who breathe pure air. So, breathing pure oxygen instead of normal air after exercise probably does not increase athletes' muscular reabsorption of oxygen.

B. None of the statements indicates that blood lactate levels cannot be reduced by means other than inhaling pure oxygen.

C. We are told that blood lactate levels are negatively correlated with muscular reabsorption of oxygen. This negative correlation might allow muscular reabsorption of oxygen to be precisely determined by measuring blood lactate levels.

D. Muscular reabsorption of oxygen might vary for reasons unrelated to whether an athlete has been inhaling pure oxygen.

E. Inhaling pure oxygen might have some legitimate role unrelated to muscular reabsorption of oxygen.

**The correct answer is A.**

676. Historian: Fifteenth-century advances in mapmaking contributed to the rise of modern nation-states. In medieval Europe (from the fifth to the fifteenth century), sovereignty centered in cities and towns and radiated outward, with boundaries often ambiguously defined. The conceptual shift toward the modern state began in the late fifteenth century, when mapmakers learned to reflect geography accurately by basing maps on latitude-longitude grids. By the mid-seventeenth century, nearly all maps showed boundary lines.

Which of the following would, if true, most strengthen the historian's reasoning?

A. Borders did not become codified in Europe until certain treaties were signed in the early nineteenth century.

B. During the medieval period, various authorities in Europe claimed power over collections of cities and towns, not contiguous territories.

C. Many members of the political elite collected maps as a hobby during the late sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries.

D. Seventeenth-century treatises and other sources of political authority describe areas of sovereignty rather than illustrate them using maps.

E. During the fifteenth century in Europe, mapmakers simplified the borders of sovereignty by drawing clear lines of demarcation between political powers.

**Argument Evaluation**

**Situation** A historian claims that fifteenth-century advances in mapmaking contributed to the rise of modern nation-states. In earlier centuries, boundaries of sovereignty in Europe were poorly

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modern nation-states. In earlier centuries, boundaries of sovereignty in Europe were poorly defined, but in the fifteenth century, maps were made based on grids showing latitude and longitude.

**Reasoning** *What additional piece of information, if true and added to the argument, would most improve the support offered for the conclusion that improved mapping contributed to the rise of nation-states?* The historian claims that there was a cause-effect relationship between progress in mapmaking and the rise of the nation-state. This claim is supported by information that territories of sovereignty were vague and ill-defined before the fifteenth century, when latitude-longitude grids began to allow progressively greater accuracy in the delineation of territories on maps. The argument assumes that the rise of nation-states would have required a high degree of clarity about each state's nonoverlapping area of sovereignty.

A. This indicates the role of treaties in the evolution of nation-states but provides no additional support for the historian's causal claim.

B. This information is consistent with the historian's belief that nothing resembling the modern state existed before the fifteenth century, but it provides no additional support for the historian's causal claim.

C. The relevance of this information to the argument is tenuous at best. There could be many nonpolitical explanations for the interest of political elites in collecting maps. Many people other than political elites may also have collected maps during the period mentioned.

D. This information tends to minimize the role of maps in defining areas of sovereignty and to cast some doubt on the historian's causal claim.

E. **Correct.** This information makes explicit the role of mapmakers in providing clarity about the geographical boundaries of each political entity's sovereignty. It thus provides additional evidence for the historian's causal claim and strengthens the historian's reasoning.

**The correct answer is E.**

677. Sascha: The attempt to ban parliament's right to pass directed-spending bills—bills that contain provisions specifically funding the favorite projects of some powerful politicians—is antidemocratic. Our nation's constitution requires that money be drawn from our treasury only when so stipulated by laws passed by parliament, the branch of government most directly representative of the citizens. This requirement is based on the belief that exercising the power to spend public resources involves the ultimate exercise of state authority and that therefore _____.

Which of the following most logically completes Sascha's argument?

A. designating funding specifically for the favorite projects of some powerful politicians should be considered antidemocratic

B. the right to exercise such a power should belong exclusively to the branch of government most directly representative of the citizens

C. exercising the power to spend public resources is in most cases—but not all—protected by the constitution

D. modifications to any spending bills should be considered expenditures authorized by law

E. only officials who are motivated by concerns for reelection should retain that power

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** According to Sascha, restricting parliament's ability to direct public money to the projects favored by powerful politicians would be undemocratic. Sascha argues that such a restriction on directed spending would be inconsistent with constitutional requirements.

**Reasoning** *What piece of information would most logically complete Sascha's argument?* What piece of information would most strongly associate parliament's spending authority with the concept of democracy? A good guess would be: some information that connects parliament's public representation role with its spending authority.

A. Sascha believes that democratic constitutional principles require that parliament remain free to do what is

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described in this sentence.

B. **Correct.** This statement makes explicit the connection, implicitly relied on by Sascha's argument, between parliament's spending authority and its role in representing the public.

C. This statement may be true but fails to associate parliament's spending authority under the constitution with the notion of democracy.

D. Bills are merely works-in-progress, texts of proposed laws. Modifications of bills do not in themselves provide legal authority for any public spending item.

E. Sascha opposes restrictions on parliament's spending power, and this would seem to imply that Sascha believes every parliamentary representative should be free to vote on such measures regardless of their levels of concern for reelection.

**The correct answer is B.**

678. Boreal owls range over a much larger area than do other owls of similar size. Scientists have hypothesized that **it is scarcity of prey that leads the owls to range so widely.** This hypothesis would be hard to confirm directly, since it is not possible to produce a sufficiently accurate count of the populations of small mammals inhabiting the forests where boreal owls live. Careful study of owl behavior has, however, shown that **boreal owls do range over larger areas when they live in regions where food of the sort eaten by small mammals is comparatively sparse.** This indicates that the scientists' hypothesis is not sheer speculation.

In the argument given, the two **boldfaced** portions play which of the following roles?

A. The first presents an explanatory hypothesis; the second states the main conclusion of the argument.

B. The first presents an explanatory hypothesis; the second presents evidence tending to support this hypothesis.

C. The first presents an explanatory hypothesis; the second presents evidence to support an alternative explanation.

D. The first describes a position that the argument opposes; the second presents evidence to undermine the support for the position being opposed.

E. The first describes a position that the argument opposes; the second states the main conclusion of the argument.

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** Boreal owls range over a much larger area than other owls of similar size. Scientists hypothesize that they do so because of prey scarcity. Counting the owls' prey—small mammals—in the boreal owls' habitat is inherently difficult. This makes the scientists' hypothesis hard to confirm directly. However, it has been found that boreal owls range widely when they inhabit regions that have relatively little food for the small mammals they prey on.

**Reasoning** *What function is served by the statement that it is scarcity of prey that leads the owls to range so widely? What function is served by the statement that boreal owls range widely if food for their small-mammal prey is relatively sparse in the region they inhabit?* The first **boldfaced** statement expresses an explanatory hypothesis. The passage explicitly says that this is a hypothesis and indicates that scientists have proposed this hypothesis as a tentative explanation for the comparatively wide range of boreal owls. The second **boldfaced** statement provides some indirect evidence for the scientists' hypothesis. The final sentence of the passage says that the immediately preceding idea (expressed in the second **boldfaced** portion) indicates that the scientists' hypothesis (the first **boldfaced** portion) is not mere speculation. The evidence expressed in this second **boldfaced** portion is indirect in that it depends heavily on further assumptions and is not sufficient to prove the hypothesis.

A. The main conclusion of the argument is that the scientists' hypothesis is not sheer speculation, i.e., that the scientists have based their hypothesis on some evidence that they have discovered. The first statement presents the scientists' hypothesis. The second statement cites some evidence for the hypothesis and is not the main conclusion of the argument.

B. **Correct.** As explained above, the first statement presents an explanatory hypothesis, while the second cites

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B. **Correct.** As explained above, the first statement presents an explanatory hypothesis, while the second cites some indirect evidence for the hypothesis.

C. The second statement cites some indirect evidence for the scientists' hypothesis, not for some other hypothesis.

D. The argument does not oppose the scientists' hypothesis, presented in the first statement; the second statement cites evidence for the hypothesis and does not cite evidence for any position the argument opposes.

E. The second statement does not present the argument's main conclusion. The main conclusion is that the scientists' hypothesis is not mere speculation.

**The correct answer is B.**

679. Cognitive scientist: Using the pioneering work of comparative psychologist Gordon Gallup as a model, several studies have investigated animals' capacity for mirror self-recognition (MSR). Most animals exposed to a mirror respond only with social behavior, such as aggression. However, in the case of the great apes, repeated exposure to mirrors leads to self-directed behaviors, such as exploring the inside of the mouth, suggesting that these animals recognize the reflection as an image of self. The implication of these studies is that the great apes have a capacity for self-awareness unique among nonhuman species.

The cognitive scientist makes which of the following assumptions in the argument above?

A. Gallup's work has established that the great apes have a capacity for MSR unique among nonhuman species.

B. If an animal does not have the capacity for MSR, it does not have the capacity for self-awareness.

C. If a researcher exposes an animal to a mirror and that animal exhibits social behavior, that animal is incapable of being self-aware.

D. When exposed to a mirror, all animals display either social behavior or self-directed behavior.

E. Animals that do not exhibit MSR may demonstrate a capacity for self-awareness in other ways.

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** A cognitive scientist claims that several studies, modeled on Gordon Gallup's work, have investigated animals' capacity for mirror self-recognition (MSR) and found that, whereas most animals exposed to a mirror exhibit only social behavior in response, great apes can come to respond with self-directed behavior. The cognitive scientist infers from this that the great apes, unique among nonhumans, have a capacity for self-awareness.

**Reasoning** *What must be true for the studies to support the cognitive scientist's conclusion?* The implicit reasoning is that an animal has self-awareness only if the animal has the capacity for MSR; if the latter is lacking, so is the capacity for self-awareness.

A. The studies the cognitive scientist's inference is based on were not necessarily conducted by Gallup himself. We are told only that they are modeled on his work.

B. **Correct.** If it were possible for an animal to have the capacity for self-awareness even if the animal lacks the capacity for MSR, then the studies would not imply that the great apes have a capacity for self-awareness that other nonhuman animal species lack.

C. The cognitive scientist's reasoning does not require that an animal with the capacity for self-awareness never exhibits social behavior when exposed to a mirror; it merely requires that it does not exhibit only such behavior.

D. The cognitive scientist's reasoning is compatible with an animal's displaying no behavior in response to exposure to a mirror.

E. The cognitive scientist's reasoning is compatible with the claim that an animal that does not exhibit MSR has no capacity at all for self-awareness.

**The correct answer is B.**

680. Last year a record number of new manufacturing jobs were created. Will this year bring another record? Well, any new manufacturing job is created either within an existing company or by the start-up of a new company.

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any new manufacturing job is created either within an existing company or by the start-up of a new company. **Within existing firms, new jobs have been created this year at well below last year's record pace.** At the same time, there is considerable evidence that the number of new companies starting up will be no higher this year than it was last year, and **there is no reason to think that the new companies starting up this year will create more jobs per company than did last year's start-ups.** So clearly, the number of new jobs created this year will fall short of last year's record.

In the argument given, the two portions in **boldface** play which of the following roles?

A. The first is a claim that the argument challenges; the second is an explicit assumption on which that challenge is based.

B. The first is a claim that the argument challenges; the second is a judgment advanced in support of the main conclusion of the argument.

C. The first provides evidence in support of the main conclusion of the argument; the second is an objection that has been raised against that main conclusion.

D. The first provides evidence in support of the main conclusion of the argument; the second is a judgment advanced in support of that main conclusion.

E. The first and the second are each claims that have been advanced in support of a position that the argument opposes.

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** Manufacturing jobs are created either within existing companies or in start-ups. Manufacturing jobs are being created at a much slower rate this year than last year. It seems likely that the number of new start-ups will not exceed last year's number and that the average number of manufacturing jobs per start-up will not exceed last year's number. So, fewer manufacturing jobs are likely to be created this year than last year.

**Reasoning** *What function is served by the statement that within existing firms, new jobs have been created this year at well below last year's record pace? What function is served by the statement that there is no reason to think that the new companies starting up this year will create more jobs per company than did last year's start-ups?* The first statement is one of the statements used as support for the argument's main conclusion (the prediction about this year's job creation). The second statement gives another premise used as support for that prediction.

A. The argument does not challenge the claim made by the first statement; it uses the first and the second statement as support for the argument's main conclusion, the prediction about this year's job creation.

B. The argument does not challenge the claim made by the first statement; it uses the first and second statements as support for the argument's main conclusion.

C. The first provides evidence in support of the main conclusion of the argument; the second is not an objection that has been raised against the main conclusion.

D. **Correct.** The first provides evidence in support of the main conclusion of the argument; the second also provides support for the main conclusion.

E. Neither the first nor the second is meant to support a position that the argument opposes; rather, they are both meant to support the argument's main conclusion.

**The correct answer is D.**

681. A study of ticket sales at a summer theater festival found that people who bought tickets to individual plays had a no-show rate of less than 1 percent, while those who paid in advance for all ten plays being performed that summer had a no-show rate of nearly 30 percent. This may be at least in part because the greater the awareness customers retain about the cost of an item, the more likely they are to use it.

Which of the following would, if true, best serve as an alternative explanation of the results of the study?

A. The price per ticket was slightly cheaper for those who bought all ten tickets in advance.

B. Many people who attended the theater festival believed strongly that they should support it financially.

C. Those who attended all ten plays became eligible for a partial refund.

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D. Usually, people who bought tickets to individual plays did so immediately prior to each performance that they attended.

E. People who arrived just before the performance began could not be assured of obtaining seats in a preferred location.

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** People who bought tickets to individual plays at a theater festival had a much lower no-show rate than did people who paid in advance for all ten plays.

**Reasoning** *What factor other than greater awareness of the ticket costs could explain why people who bought tickets individually were more likely to attend the plays?* The passage suggests that people who bought tickets individually were more likely to attend the plays because they were more vividly aware of what they had paid for each ticket. But there are other possible explanations—perhaps the people who bought the tickets individually were more eager to attend each play for its own sake, or they had other characteristics or incentives that made them more likely to attend the plays.

A. A slight price difference would not plausibly explain why the no-show rate was thirty times greater among those who bought all the tickets in advance than among those who bought them individually.

B. This could be true of many people who bought their tickets individually as well as many who bought them in advance.

C. This would provide an added incentive for those who bought tickets in advance to attend all the plays.

D. **Correct.** If people who bought individual tickets usually did so right before each performance, they would have much less time after buying the tickets to change their minds about whether to attend than would people who bought all the tickets in advance.

E. If anything, this might present an additional difficulty for those who bought individual tickets without advance planning, so it would not help to explain the lower no-show rate among buyers of individual tickets.

**The correct answer is D.**

682. Although there is no record of poet Edmund Spenser's parentage, we do know that as a youth Spenser attended the Merchant Tailors' School in London for a period between 1560 and 1570. Records from this time indicate that the Merchant Tailors' Guild then had only three members named Spenser: Robert Spenser, listed as a gentleman; Nicholas Spenser, elected the Guild's Warden in 1568; and John Spenser, listed as a "journeyman cloth-maker." Of these, the last was likely the least affluent of the three—and most likely Edmund's father, since school accounting records list Edmund as a scholar who attended the school at a reduced fee.

Which of the following is an assumption on which the argument depends?

A. Anybody in sixteenth-century London who made clothing professionally would have had to be a member of the Merchant Tailors' Guild.

B. The fact that Edmund Spenser attended the Merchant Tailors' School did not necessarily mean that he planned to become a tailor.

C. No member of the Guild could become Guild warden in sixteenth-century London unless he was a gentleman.

D. Most of those whose fathers were members of the Merchant Tailors' Guild were students at the Merchant Tailors' School.

E. The Merchant Tailors' School did not reduce its fees for the children of the more affluent Guild members.

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** Records indicate that the poet Edmund Spenser attended the Merchant Tailors' School for a reduced fee as a youth. There is no record of his parentage, but at the time, the Merchant Tailors' Guild had only three members named Spenser, of whom the least affluent was probably John Spenser.

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Spenser.

**Reasoning** *What must be true in order for the cited facts to support the conclusion that John Spenser was probably Edmund Spenser's father?* The implicit reasoning is that since Edmund Spenser attended the Merchant Tailors' School at a reduced fee, his father must have been poor. And since John Spenser was probably the poorest of the three men named Spenser in the Merchant Tailors' Guild, he was probably Edmund Spenser's father. This reasoning assumes that only the children of poor parents had reduced fees at the Merchant Tailors' School, that the children at the school generally had fathers in the Merchant Tailors' Guild, that children in that time and place generally shared their fathers' surnames, and that the two other Spensers in the Merchant Tailors' Guild were not poor enough for their children to qualify for reduced fees.

A. John Spenser, as a tailor and member of the Guild, could have been Edmund Spenser's father even if some other professional tailors did not belong to the Guild and did not have children at the school.

B. Although Edmund Spenser became a poet as an adult, he and all his classmates might have attended the school as children because they planned to become tailors.

C. The argument assumes that a Guild's Warden probably would have been wealthier than a journeyman cloth-maker, but that might have been probable even if the Guild's Warden were not a "gentleman."

D. Even if most children of fathers in the Guild did not attend the school, all the children who did attend the school might have had fathers in the Guild.

E. **Correct.** If the school reduced its fees for children of wealthier Guild members, then the fact that Edmund Spenser's fees were reduced would not provide evidence that his father was the poorest of the three Spensers in the Guild, as the argument requires.

**The correct answer is E.**

683.

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